

Mustelids

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Carnivora
FAMILY	Mustelidae
SPECIES	57

Of all the carnivores, the mustelid family is the most diverse and contains the most species. The group includes terrestrial forms (such as ferrets), arboreal species (such as martens), burrowing species (such as badgers), semiaquatic species (such as minks), and fully aquatic species

(such as otters). With such a range of lifestyles, the main physical link between species is short legs and an elongated body. Mustelids are found throughout Eurasia, Africa, and the Americas. Although mostly occurring in forest or bush, they have adapted to populate almost every habitat type.

Anatomy

All mustelids have short ears and 5 toes on each foot (most carnivores have only 4 on each back foot); most have a short snout, a long braincase, a long tail, and long, nonretractable, curved claws. Body form tends to be either slender (as in weasels) or heavy and squat (as in badgers). Slimmer forms have a flexible backbone and employ a scampering, bounding gait; stocky forms move with a rolling shuffle. Mustelids have a fur coat that consists of warm underfur and longer, sparser guard hairs. Coat color varies from dark brown or black to spotted or striped. In some species, contrasting

patterns—for example, the black-and-white striped heads of badgers—are thought to convey a warning to predators.

Most mustelids have an excellent sense of smell for tracking prey and for communication. All have scent glands in the anus, which generally produce an oily, strong-smelling liquid known as musk. This is secreted into the feces, which are used to mark territory.

Feeding

Reflecting their diverse lifestyles, mustelids have a varied diet. Weasels and stoats, for example, are agile and aggressive and are capable of killing prey larger than themselves, such as rabbits. Some otter species actively hunt fish; others eat mainly shellfish collected by feeling along riverbeds with their sensitive paws. The sea otter cracks open abalone shells by floating on its back on the surface and then hitting the shell against a rock balanced on its chest. Martens, which are arboreal, catch and eat squirrels and birds, while the zorilla, a burrowing species, catches small rodents, lizards, and insects.

Reproduction

Many female mustelids do not ovulate automatically. Instead, ovulation is stimulated by copulation, which may last up to 2 hours. This lengthy procedure does expose pairs to predators, but fertilization is almost guaranteed. In many species, the fertilized egg remains dormant and does not implant until conditions are favorable. Therefore, although the gestation period is only 1–2 months, pregnancy may last more than 12 months. Most mustelids are solitary, except during the breeding season.

Fur trade

Mustelid fur is highly valued by humans for its softness, warmth, and water-repelling qualities. The fur of mink, sable, stoat, and sea otter were much sought after and became particularly fashionable in the first half of the 20th century. So great was the demand that the American mink was farmed, and in Europe, escapees have established wild populations, often at the expense of the indigenous European mink. Today, people often prefer to have fake fur, and hunting is either prohibited or controlled by legislation. Some mustelids are still farmed commercially for their fur but in many countries this, too, is now illegal.



AQUATIC HUNTER

The American mink is a voracious hunter, as is typical of mustelids. This species, like all minks and otters, is an excellent swimmer. It can remain submerged for distances of up to 98 ft (30 m) in pursuit of fish, which forms an important part of its diet. Adaptations to a semiaquatic lifestyle include partially webbed feet and a thick, waterproof coat.